

Dr. Freitas | Language Lab Syllabus

World Languages & Culture | Middle School | Mary, Star of the Sea School

School Year 2026-2027

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Mary, Star of the Sea School Mission

Nurture, Unite, Inspire. We are committed to nurturing each child's curiosity, uniting our classroom in respect and collaboration, and inspiring every student to grow in knowledge, faith, and wonder for the world around them.

2026-2027 Essential Question

"How can I model kindness, fairness, and humility like Jesus?"

Language Lab Vision & NUI Mission

The vision of the Middle School Language Lab is to provide students with the opportunity to develop proficiency in a second language while also gaining a deeper understanding and appreciation of the culture(s) associated with that language. Aligned with our school's NUI mission, this course:

- **Nurtures** foundational communication skills by balancing structured lessons with personal growth.
- **Unites** students and cultures through meaningful cross-cultural comparisons and exposure to global perspectives.
- **Inspires** curiosity and lifelong learning through engaging tools like Duolingo and cultural exploration.

At Mary, Star of the Sea School, we guide our students to become S.T.A.R.s:

- Self-Aware, Confident Individuals
- Teachable, Lifelong Independent Learners
- Active Christians
- Responsible Citizens

Curriculum Overview

The curriculum is well-rounded and covers both language skills and cultural topics.

- **Language skills** - Grammar, Vocabulary, Pronunciation.
- **Cultural topics** - History, Traditions, Social norms.

Students are exposed to authentic resources such as videos, songs, and texts, and are encouraged to use the language in real-world scenarios. Language options are based on availability in high school to support long-term learning.

Languages Offered

- Spanish
- French
- Japanese
- Hawaiian

Objective & Grading

The Language Lab aims to develop students' listening, speaking, reading, and writing skills in their chosen language through the Duolingo for Schools program, supported by in-class speaking practice, cultural projects, and ACTFL-aligned activities.

Students will regularly:

- Complete interactive lessons online
- Participate in role-plays and discussions
- Listen to guest speakers
- Engage in hands-on cultural learning

Category	Weight	Description
Completion of Units / Lessons	50%	Duolingo progress, language binders, worksheets; in-class activities and immersive learning. 1 pt taken off for late work.
Assessments & Projects	35%	Quizzes, presentations, cultural projects, and writing assignments that showcase growth and understanding.
Behavior / Participation	15%	Active engagement, appropriate use of tech, headphone etiquette, and participation in group / cultural activities. Points deducted daily for poor participation.

Required Supplies

- USB-C or gaming-style headphones (with microphone)
- 1" Language Lab binder and composition notebook
- MacBook (charged daily)

Duolingo Scope & Sequence

- **Grade 6** - Level 1 (Introduction): Greetings, colors, numbers, basic nouns/pronouns, weather.
- **Grade 7** - Level 2 (Foundations): Daily routines, food, describing people and places.
- **Grade 8** - Level 3 (Intermediate): Travel, past tense, expressing emotions.
- **Advanced (dedicated students)** - Level 4/5 (Communication and Fluency): Future tense, complex sentences, advanced grammar; opinions, current events, specialized vocabulary.

Along the language-learning journey, students aren't just learning words. 6th grade students gain the tools to connect with new people, explore different cultures, and see the world with fresh eyes. 7th grade continues to strengthen their foundational vocabulary and 8th grade begins their true experience of learning how to communicate with more complex grammar. This foundation sets them up to enter high school at Level 2 in their target language.

Language learning is a journey that takes patience and dedication. Even if your child isn't speaking fluently right away, they are building strong foundations that -- through consistent effort -- will grow into the ability to communicate confidently in the future.

Units by Quarter

Each grade advances through a set of language and cultural units aligned to the Duolingo scope above.

Grade 6

- Q1 - Introductions, alphabet, indefinite and definite articles, classroom vocabulary.
- Q2 - More practice with articles, singular and plural, fall and winter vocabulary and traditions.
- Q3 - Numbers, calendar, days of the week, months, birthdays, holidays.
- Q4 - Weather and seasons, final year-end project.

Grade 7

- Q1 - Review; personal pronouns, adjectives and verbs; descriptive vocabulary.
- Q2 - Food and restaurant vocabulary, more verbs, holiday foods and traditions.
- Q3 - Family vocabulary, possessive pronouns, and family gatherings.
- Q4 - Grocery shopping and 4th-quarter project.

Grade 8

- Q1 - Review; city vocabulary; city descriptions with adjectives and prepositions.
- Q2 - Directions, public transportation, maps, and navigation.
- Q3 - Clothing, shopping, and community vocabulary.
- Q4 - Vacation vocabulary and 4th-quarter project.

Parent Involvement

We love guests and would love to have you come and help out or speak to the class! Please contact me at bfreitas@starofthesea.org if you:

- Speak a world language
- Have traveled internationally
- Want to share culture or stories

"Come explore the world through language!"

Empowered to Succeed, Guided by Faith